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THE KNOWLEDGE



Alexander Cunningham’s mysterious stone seal from Harappa.

It may strike the reader as perverse that I should now devote an entire chapter to early developments north of the Narmada. But the fact is that much of what shaped or influenced the culture of the Indian South had roots in the North. So bear with me, dear reader, if I begin by writing about what, for the sake of simplicity and to avoid raising hackles, I shall call the Harappan Civilisation,[1] taking its name from the place where its archaeological potential was first spotted by an army deserter, an eccentric Englishman named James Price who chose to reinvent himself as ‘Charles Masson, an American gentleman from Kentucky’.

In 1826 Masson was crossing the Punjab on his way to Afghanistan when he made camp at a small village he called Haripah, beside a dried-up watercourse in what is now